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Erotics, Gender and Violence in Greek and Roman Myth

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Echoes of Love: The Parodistic Nature of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*

In Plato's *Symposium*, Aristophanes paints a picture of sexual relationships between humans that portrays said relationships as beautiful, inborn parts of human nature (191d). Humans, existing as lone halves of a former whole, constantly seek their other halves in order to return to their original state of wholeness through copulation with each other (193a). Sexual desire—described by Aristophanes as “the desire and pursuit of wholeness” (193a)—is the expression by the human soul of its deepest wish (192d) and serves to “heal human nature” (191d). But what happens when this state of wholeness can never be achieved? What happens when one pays no mind to this sacred mission and instead falls in love with himself? According to Aristophanes, an inability to copulate with their beloveds leads humans to untimely death (191b), which can be seen illustrated by Ovid through the story of Narcissus and Echo in the *Metamorphoses*. Narcissus rejects the human nature laid out by Aristophanes, and in falling in love with himself, stumbles into the trap of a similar fate. Similarly, in the face of unrequited love, Echo withers away and vanishes into the air. Through the story of Narcissus, Ovid directly (and humorously) pokes fun at Aristophanes' philosophy in order to critique the ideas it perpetuates.

As a comedic writer, it makes complete sense that Aristophanes would produce an absurd, humorous story. Portraying humans as having originated from four-armed, four-legged, two-headed ball-like beings (190a) is inherently fantastical, and obviously wouldn't occur in reality. Ovid's twist on said story, then, is also incredibly absurd in tone. Even in his infancy, Narcissus is portrayed as "a child whom, even then, one could fall in love with" (3.339-358). As he ages, he is portrayed as a fool who initially cannot discern his own reflection (which presumably moves the same way he does and looks exactly like him) from another living, breathing person (3.402-436). In his death, the metamorphosis of his body into a flower is presumably a surprise to the nymphs, who had been "preparing the funeral pyre, the quivering torches, and the bier" (3.474-510) for a body that they would never come upon. That is to say, none of these examples are at all accurate to what occurs in the real world, and they can be perceived by the reader as being incredibly humorous. By using a similar tone as Aristophanes, Ovid is able to put a similarly humorous spin on his speech via Narcissus in the *Metamorphoses*.

In addition to their similarities in tone, the two stories have numerous parallels that show how Ovid builds off of Aristophanes' work. In the *Symposium*, Aristophanes says that when lovers meet "they are then marvelously struck by friendship and kinship and Eros, and are scarcely willing to be separated from each other even for a little time" (192c). We see Narcissus act in a very similar way in the *Metamorphoses*, as once he lays his gaze upon his reflection and regards the unattainable boy as his beloved, he refuses to leave his spot by the fountain. "No care for *Cere's* gift of bread," Ovid writes, "or for rest, can draw him away" (3.437-473). Not only is he scarcely unwilling to be separated from that boy in his reflection, but Ovid describes him as

being “astonished by himself” (3.402-436) such that he “inflames and burns” (3.402-436) for his own reflection, having been struck by the kinship and desire described by Aristophanes.

When Narcissus realizes that his beloved is in fact only his own reflection, and is consequently unattainable, he essentially decides to lie down and die. He laments that “sadness takes away [his] strength, not much time is left for [him] to live, and [he] is cut off in the prime of his youth” (3.437-473). His starvation, exhaustion, and despair overtake him, subsequently killing him. This parallels the fate of the original humans that Aristophanes describes in the *Symposium*, before they were able to copulate with each other. Since they were unwilling to do anything but lie in the embrace of their other half, these humans were just dying of exhaustion (191b), similarly to how the unwillingness of Narcissus to leave his reflection also leads him to starve to death.

The death of Narcissus itself also points to another larger parallel between the two works, which is that of change. In the *Symposium*, the original humans undergo a severe metamorphosis in being cleaved into two halves; this change leads to many of their deaths, before the problem is fixed by Zeus. Narcissus too undergoes a metamorphosis, as his corpse upon his death suddenly turns into a beautiful flower “with white petals surrounding a yellow heart” (3.474-510). Not only does this transformation continue the theme of change present in both works, but it serves to connect Narcissus to the original humans by returning him to the earth. According to Aristophanes, the original humans were “[begetting] and [bearing] children not in each other but in the earth, like locusts” (191c). Narcissus transforming into a flower, a plant that grows straight up from the soil, returns him in death to part of his original, sacred nature. This presents these

changes as almost cyclical in nature. The original humans, who are born from the earth, are cleaved in two. Narcissus, presumably descended from these ‘cleaved’ humans, returns to the earth upon his death.

Echo as a character is also important to speak on, as she exemplifies many of the same parallels to the early humans as Narcissus does. While she is a nymph— a nonhuman being which the mother and sisters of Narcissus are as well (3.339-358)— she is still mortal, and eventually meets a similar fate to Narcissus and the original humans. Upon seeing Narcissus, she is struck with the same desire that he experiences, and that Aristophanes describes. Ovid writes that she “[burns] with fire, no differently than inflammable sulphur... she wants to get close to him with seductive words, and call to him with soft entreaties!” (3.359-401). However, when Narcissus rejects her love, shouting for her to get “‘Away, with [her] encircling hands’” (3.359-401), she realizes that attaining his love is an impossible task. In a very similar fashion to the deaths of Narcissus and the original humans, she withers away and loses her corporeal form. “Her sleepless thoughts waste her sad form,” Ovid writes, “and her body’s strength vanishes into the air. Only her bones and the sound of her voice are left” (3.359-401). While she doesn’t exactly die as the others do, retaining her consciousness and the sound of her voice, the unrequited nature of her love essentially reduces her to nothing. Echo’s inclusion in the story of Narcissus strengthens these parallels and her vanishing contributes to the fantastical tone of the work.

These parallels between the two works— from a similar tone, to similar story beats, to similar themes— show how Ovid takes the concepts introduced by Aristophanes and morphs

them into a sort of twisted parody of the original speech by showcasing what would occur if one were to come face to face with unrequited or unattainable love in the fantastical, absurdist world described in the *Symposium*. A question that might then arise from this argument is why Ovid would even want to make fun of Aristophanes' speech in the first place. There are some problems with the philosophy that Aristophanes presents, namely the ideas that lust is part of what makes us human (as it allows us to return to our original, 'true' nature), and that if the sexual relationships that come from said lust are unattainable, the best option becomes succumbing to a long and painful death. These ideas are troubling, at best; In the real world, not everyone finds—or is even interested in finding—the person who may or may not complete them. To perpetuate the idea that one cannot be whole without a sexual partner automatically alienates those who do not want or cannot have such experiences. It can leave people feeling empty, belittled or less than. Furthermore, the idea that someone else can make one 'whole' and fix every present problem is also untrue. Another person can't 'heal' you or make whole what is 'broken;' you need to fix yourself and find what makes you whole outside of the validation of another person. Are those who find themselves unable to pursue their beloved destined to die alone, in despair and anguish, having never fulfilled their purpose, as Narcissus does in the *Metamorphoses*? Will they vanish into thin air, as Echo did?

The answer to this question is that it absolutely isn't the case. Aristophanes' speech is one in a large collection of Greek and Roman works that portray death as the immediate response to unrequited or unattainable love (mythological figures who actively commit suicide for this reason include the likes of Dido and Phaedra, to name a few). The idea is absurd, as is the speech of Aristophanes. Through the story of Narcissus and Echo in the *Metamorphoses*, Ovid twists

these ideas into a humorous parody of the *Symposium*, which stands as a critique of Aristophanes as well as the prevalent themes in the work of his peers.